Quick infobytes
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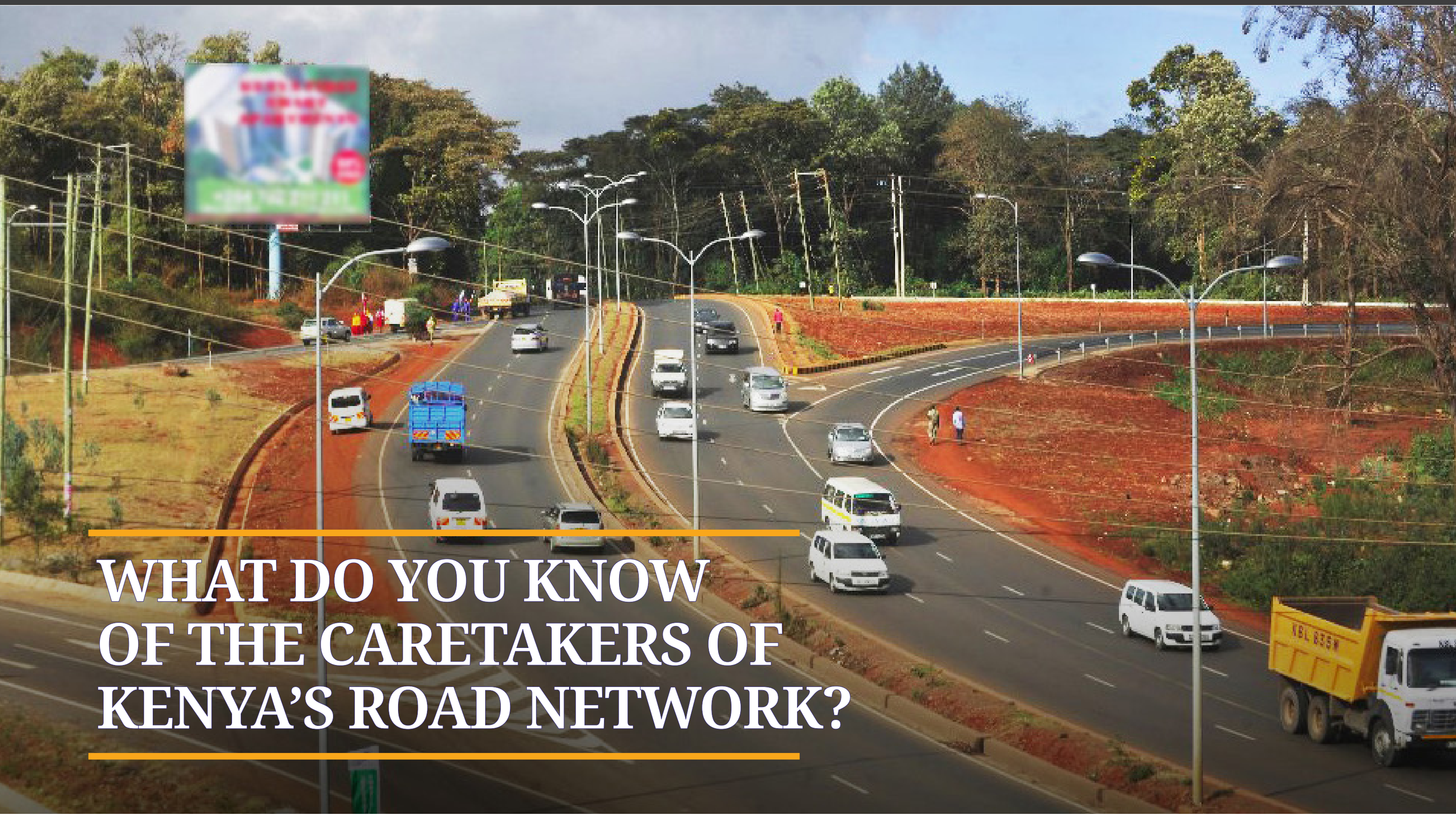
Making your dailies more informative



WHAT DO YOU KNOW OF THE CARETAKERS OF KENYA'S ROAD NETWORK?

The Greek said, "Show me your friends and I will tell you who you are." Me, I say, "Show me your roads, and I'll tell you the state of your economy." Because, like arteries pulse with life-sustaining blood around a body, so do roads in an economy. Infrastructure link producers to markets, workers to jobs, students to school, the sick to hospitals. It touches every sector of the economy and are the most important of all public assets. Yet, due to use and time, these corridors do age and require maintenance, renewal and modernisation. So to whom do you entrust such a vital responsibility? Most Kenyans will probably say KeNHA, or KURA, or KeRRA, and they'll be partially right. These agencies do the physical work on the ground. But there's a mother organisation, one that brings the three, plus KWS, together. It's the *Kenya Roads Board*, the star of this 25th issue of *Quick InfoBytes*. *Karibu*...

The Editor

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Who is the Kenya Roads Board?

The Kenya Roads Board (KRB) is a State Corporation established under KRB ACT No. 7, of 1999 to oversee the road network in Kenya. The Board coordinates the maintenance, rehabilitation and development of these infrastructure through the KRB Fund and also advises the Minister for Transport on all matters related thereto.

Is KRB the same as KeNHA or KURA?

Not. Besides playing an oversight role over KeNHA, KURA, KeRRA, the Board is also responsible for funding these the road agencies. It does this using the Road Maintenance Levy Fund (RMLF). The Kenya Wildlife Service (KWS) also gets a share of the RMLF to develop and maintain roads in national parks and game reserves.

Explain KeNHA, KURA, KeRRA...

The agencies were established in 2007, through the Kenya Roads Act. They make up three of four pillars (2,3 &4) identified in the 1980s by the Road Maintenance Initiative, a component of the Sub-Saharan Africa Transport Programme supported by the World Bank, as key to reversing deteriorating road network. Kenya Roads Board fulfils pillars 1,2 and 3.

What determines the amount allocated to each agency?

The KRB Act provides for the allocation of funds to the Road Agencies. KeNHA receives 40 per cent, KeRRA 25 per cent, KURA 15 per cent and Kenya Wildlife Service 1 per cent of the Fund. The Board reviews annual road work plans submitted by the Road Agencies and consolidates them into the Annual Public Roads Programme (APRP) which outlines the planned road works and specifies the amount allocated to each.

What numbers are we talking about in the FY2021/22?

In the FY 2021-2022, KeNHA (Classes S, A & B) will receive Sh26,592,551,020, and KeRRA (Class C) Ksh. 14, 590,870,343. KURA (Urban Roads Classes UA, UB & UC) and KWS (Roads within National Parks and Game Reserves) has been allocated Kshs. 6,651,970,473 and Kshs. 651,338,776 respectively

Tell us about the Road Maintenance Levy

The Fund was established through the Road Maintenance Levy Fund (RMLF) Act of 1993 to provide a sustainable source of funding for the maintenance of the road network. The fund has steadily grown from Sh8 billion in 2002 to over Sh80 billion today.

And the Fuel Levy Fund?

The KRB Fund comprises mainly of fuel levy and transit tolls. Fuel levy is a user-charge on petrol and diesel at KSh18 per litre. Of this, Sh3 is applied towards the Road Annuity Fund to upgrade 10,000km of roads with asphalt surfacing. Transit tolls are charged on transit vehicles plying Kenyan roads.

How effective has RMLF been over the years?

Kenya's classified road network has increased from 41,800 km at independence to 63,575 km today, a development rate of no less than 600 km per annum. During the same period, the paved road length grew from 1,811 km to 9,273 km. It is presently estimated that about 70 per cent (44,100 km) of the classified road network is in good condition and is maintainable while the remaining 30 per cent (18,900 km) requires rehabilitation or reconstruction.

Why are roads so important?

Transportation is a key driver of socio-economic growth in every country making infrastructure a key driver of any nation's development. Good roads enable farmers and other producers to get their produce to the market and at less cost. Countries with the best roads make mobility and distribution of goods and services faster and easier. This goes a long way to improve the bottom line of companies and improves the country's GDP.

How does road classification work?

It is the orderly grouping of roads and in Kenya, this can be administratively (National or County Roads) and/or Functionally (Class A, B.... G). Administrative classification assigns road ownership and management to Road Agencies while functional classification presides over technical requirements and maintenance practices. Kenya Roads Board undertakes road classification on behalf of the Ministry of Transport, Infrastructure, Housing, Urban Development & Public Works.

Is the roads categorisation necessary?

Absolutely. It's applied in planning road network system development and to determine the appropriate jurisdictional responsibility for different roads. It is also used as a guide for developing design standards for various types of roads and for fiscal planning.

Which roads are under county governments?

The County Governments are in- charge of all roads (rural and Urban) in classes D,E, F and G.

How does KWS tie into road maintenance?

The Board allocates one per cent of the monies from the RMLF to the Kenya Wildlife Service for road maintenance in national parks and reserves. It is through these monies, for instance, that KWS acquired construction equipment and supervision vehicles worth Sh140 million late last year. The equipment included three graders and seven road maintenance and inspection vehicles.

Graduate Engineers Internship Programme?

It is a platform established by KRB and the road agencies to help graduate engineers gain professional hands-on experience and register with the Engineering Board of Kenya. The first cohort of the graduate engineers (15) were enrolled in April 2020 while the second cohort (22) enrolled in January 2021. All have so far been posted either to KRB or the road agencies.

How long does it take to complete the programme?

The Graduate Engineers Internship Programme takes three years. On completion of the programme, the graduate engineers will apply for registration as engineers with the Engineers Board of Kenya and enter into the professional engineering field.

How does KRB ensure Kenyans get value for money?

The Board undertakes technical, performance and fund inspection of all the projects financed by the Road Maintenance Levy fund. This is done inhouse and through civil engineering and financial consultants. The inspection is to ascertain the quality of work done and that the funds have not only been used for the intended purpose, but that the application has been done in an economic, efficient and effective manner.

What road safety campaigns is KRB involved in?

The Board is in the process of implementing a road mainstreaming strategy to increase public awareness on road safety. A main focus of the initiative is the training, licensing, provision of personal protective equipment for boda boda riders as well as institutional support to hospitals' trauma centres. KRB has also signed a Memorandum of Understanding with NTSA to support various road safety initiatives such as public education

And progress of the road safety programme?

The Board had toured 13 counties and trained about 5,000 riders, provided 3,000 helmets, 10,000 reflective jackets and first aid kits by end of 2021. Further, 150 riders had sat and passed licensing examination by National Transport and Safety Authority (NTSA).

What else is the board doing?

KRB has been working to automate most of its data processing and services and has now deployed a Spatial Web Map Portal to ease access to roads data by the public. As such, Kenya Roads Board's geo-resources which include data and information on the road network of Kenya, maps and infographics are now easily accessible through Board's web portal.

Did Covid affect KRB's objectives?

The pandemic disrupted nearly every aspect of the economy and the resulting ripple effects felt across every sector were a major threat to the achievement of the Board's strategic objectives. The Board was, however, able to adapt with measures that ensured continuity of work and keep it on track. The Board is currently being guided by the Strategic Plan 2018-2022 which is aligned to Kenya's vision 2030 and the Big Four Agenda.

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